product of much more recent immigration from non-European countries. In addition, Bosnia, long before the war started, had a historic record of genuine religious tolerance and a tradition of secular Islam. In many respects, secular Bosnian Islam was actually the main building element in the country that today we call Bosnia and Herzegovina – a fact that the local ethnic Serbs and also Croats do not much like to hear. While some may have doubts whether Turkey lies in Europe, there is certainly no doubt about the position of Bosnia.

For some time, the country has been trying very hard (but perhaps not hard enough) to reach an agreement between the Serbs, the Bosniaks and the Croats over future constitutional arrangements. The EU even went so far as to bend slightly what were originally very tough criteria, which led the country to sign the Stabilisation and Association Agreement in June 2008 – something that was met with great joy all over Bosnia and Herzegovina. But the momentum was soon lost and the EU and the US continue to be concerned that the ethnically almost purified Republika Srpska will simply go its own way, uninterested in doing business with the Muslim-Croat part of the country, where many Croats too look more to Zagreb than Sarajevo.

But imagine what a more sensible approach by the Serbs, Croats and Muslims alike could do for the country, making it, at some point in the future, the first EU member state with a sizeable indigenous Muslim population. In an era of tense relations between the Western (nominally Christian) world and the Muslim world, this could be an added value for the European Union. When the EU candidate status was granted to Ukraine and Moldova in June 2022, some of the Central European countries called for Bosnia and Herzegovina to be treated the same, simply to end the internal deadlock in the country, but most of the EU-27 remain unconvinced – and Bosnia and Herzegovina had to wait a few more months before the European Commission proposed a candidate status for the country in October 2022.

Further south-east, Albania, which is also traditionally a Muslim country, is making an enormous effort to shake off the legacy of its brutal Communist past. It has a long way to go, although, by entering NATO in 2009, it made a great leap forward. Its neighbour and cousin, Kosovo, the sanctuary of Orthodox Serbia, finally got its long-awaited independence in 2008. No one saw it as an ideal solution. But in the end most governments